

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

72-hour emergency kit

PREPAREDNESS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Start with at least three days of safe water, ready-to-eat food, essential medicines, lighting and communication supplies. Include one gallon of water per person per day as a starting point, and account for pets, heat, medical needs and accessibility.

Do now.

**Inventory what you own**

01

Gather usable supplies before buying duplicates.

**Cover essentials**

02

Choose safe water, shelf-stable food, a can opener, light, radio, batteries and phone charging.

**Personalize**

03

Add medication arrangements, eyeglasses, infant needs, pet supplies, hygiene and accessible equipment.

**Maintain the kit**

04

Label dates, rotate food and water as instructed and check supplies routinely.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If shops close today, inventory water, shelf-stable food, medicine and batteries already at home. Put them together and write down gaps. Build a usable kit in stages; a partly stocked kit is more useful than waiting for an expensive perfect one.

Watch for.

A standard checklist is only a starting point; three days may not cover a prolonged disruption.

People & practical needs.

Start with the people in the home: drinking water, medicines, infant feeding, sensory access, safe light and pet care. Choose who will carry shared items. A 72-hour kit is a planning starting point, not a guarantee that a disruption ends after three days.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Build longer-duration supplies as space and budget allow. Keep an evacuation bag separate enough to carry.

Check the next usable option

Build longer-duration supplies as space and budget allow. Keep an evacuation bag separate enough to carry.

When the first option is unavailable

If shops close today, inventory water, shelf-stable food, medicine and batteries already at home. Put them together and write down gaps. Build a usable kit in stages; a partly stocked kit is more useful than waiting for an expensive perfect one.

Questions in the field.

How much can the household carry?

Separate supplies stored at home from a bag intended for evacuation. Test carrying the bag with the actual caregiver and mobility needs. Heavy water and duplicate tools can make a complete-looking kit unusable when movement matters.

What if a supply expires?

Use normal household rotation where suitable and record refill dates. Check battery and device compatibility before relying on them. Medicine quantities and replacements require a clinician or pharmacist rather than an improvised rationing plan.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

72-hour emergency kit · official guidance

<https://www.ready.gov/kit>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/72-hour-kit/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.